



event that is expected to cost the country close to Rs 6,000 crore whose results will have little bearing at the Asian Games or Olympic Games. India's sports officials bid for such Games only because it is far easier to stage two-week sports extravaganza (through which friends in the construction and hospitality lobby can be rewarded), rather than work actively to raise a nation out of sporting mediocrity.

SHOW SPORT THE MONEY

The Chinese and in these Games the British have proved yet again that no country can succeed at global sport without adequate and well-directed funding. Britain, host of the 2012 London Olympics, was the surprise performer of the Games finishing fourth behind China, the USA and Russia with 47 medals including 19

gold. Since its 36th spot in the 1996 Atlanta Olympics, British sport has overhauled its funding and begun to use a portion of National Lottery earnings to support its best athletes. UK Sport, the body that funds the highest rung of British athletes, received £115.8 million last year from the treasury and the National Lottery. From 2005 onwards, it is believed elite British athletes received more than £235 million directed towards the Beijing Olympics effort. Athletes like cyclist Chris Hoy, Beijing multiple gold medallist, received £75,000 a year with £50,000 set aside for his coaching, training and medical expenses. Around £400 million more is expected to be made available to British athletes towards their London 2012.

There is today, no shortage of funds in India with private enterprise stepping forward to help athletes: it is the duty of the federations to look for alternative

sources of funding in the corporate sector rather than sponge irresponsibly from the Government and even more importantly to direct the funds to be made available where they are needed most. Like the Chinese, India must build on its sporting strengths.

DREAM BIG, THINK MICRO

India's sports facilities are poor and could do with upgradation but to increase its pool of competitors, the country needs to think micro. According to Sports Ministry figures, of 70 crore Indians under the age of 35, only five crore have organised access to sport. By ignoring its supply chain, Indian sport has cut off its own oxygen. According to badminton coach Pullela Gopichand, it would require little more than a rudimentary court in every town to pull more children into a sport

ACCORDING TO THE UNION SPORTS MINISTRY FIGURES, OF 70 CRORE INDIANS UNDER THE AGE OF 35, ONLY FIVE CRORE HAVE ORGANISED ACCESS TO ANY KIND OF SPORT.



PATHETIC: Delhi's Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium will host 2010 Commonwealth Games